China's challenge to American "power, influence, and interests," arguing that the United States was engaged in a "geopolitical competition" with Beijing, one between "free and repressive visions of world order."[38] The document signaled that while Trump would pursue cooperation where possible with China, his administration would put China's aggressive security and predatory economic policies at the top of the agenda. The National Security Strategy was followed in mid-2019 by the Department of Defense's *Indo-Pacific Strategy Report*, the first such US document since the Clinton administration more than two decades previously.[39] Explicitly claiming that the Indo-Pacific is the Pentagon's "priority theater," the strategy report sharpened the idea that the United States and China are engaged in a long-term struggle for influence and power in the Indo-Pacific.

Following up on his campaign promises, Trump announced in early 2018 a series of new tariffs on Chinese steel, and demanded that the bilateral trade deficit be reduced by at least $100 billion. Though darkly warning of a trade war and imposing a retaliatory 10 percent tariff on $60 billion worth of US goods, Beijing nonetheless responded with various proposals for evening out the unbalanced trade between the two countries. Throughout 2018 and 2019 the two sides failed to reach agreement on market access for US firms and the reduction of trade barriers. This led Trump to levy 25 percent tariffs on $250 billion worth of Chinese goods and to announce 10 percent tariffs on a further $300 million worth.[40] By the summer of 2019, relations between Beijing and Washington had cooled significantly, with Chinese media and diplomatic officials blaming America for everything from China's economic slowdown to anti-Chinese demonstrations rocking Hong Kong.

The Fundamentals of US Strategy in the Indo-Pacific Region

Acknowledging Asia's new realities during the late-Obama and Trump eras started a process of reshaping US policy to achieve national goals,